



Trot back to the last time we did a PC comparison (October 2001)—the top dog then snarled with the combined power of the 1.5 GHz Pentium 4 processor and a GeForce 3 graphics accelerator, and was armed to the teeth with peripherals. In terms of sheer performance, it managed to wow even some of the more stringent reviewers in the Digit Test Centre. Many a megahertz, megabyte and rendered pixels later, the envelope of what's considered to be hot technology is still being pushed further.

The advancements in technology have resulted in quantum leaps in system performance and amazing features—GeForce 4 Ti 4600 graphics cards, searing-fast DDR and RDRAM and of course, the ever spiralling clock speeds of today's processors have brought some serious horsepower onto your desktop, at relatively low prices.

Given their complexity, these products need robust after-sales support and warranties. Customer support is as important as the usual parameters of performance and features—comprehensive, countrywide after-sales support and service spells the difference between a branded PC and a locally assembled one.

Digit Test Process

For a PC to be accepted as branded, it had to fulfil a set of criteria. First it should have a distinctive logo and a national presence with authorised service centres in at least all the major metro cities. Besides, a particular PC model should come with a constant configuration, regardless of where in the country it is sold. A branded PC is also required to include a licensed operating system or a recovery CD that carries the licensed software.

The PCs received in our Test Centre were of the same configuration as those found in the market, with the necessary peripherals, supporting software and documentation included. They were tested 'as they were'—we did not tweak or load additional software into them, except the benchmarking applications. This was done to capture the performance as would be experienced by the end-user. Finally, to complete the picture, we also tested the bundled peripheral components such as printer, scanner, monitor and speakers.

Test methodology

The PCs were tested on four primary parameters: features (30 per cent), performance (40 per cent), value for money (20 per cent) and warranty and support (10 per cent). The weightages allotted to each parameter was used to calculate the overall scores.

Features: The various features of the PCs were divided into four major categories:

a) System configuration and bundled peripherals: We noted specifications such as the processor type, amount of RAM, hard disk type, motherboard, CD/DVD/CD-RW drive, graphics card, motherboard, etc. The better the specifications that a computer boasted, the higher it scored in this category.

b) Build quality: To evaluate build quality, we noted aspects such as the overall layout of the components within the system cabinet, roominess and airflow within the systems through additional fans and ducts and attention to details such as tied IDE